of seven-year-old Salim's fever. The astrologers agreed with their emperor, as did the fortune-tellers; but the ladies of the harem were not quite as firm of faith. They did not want predictions, they wanted 'skilful physicians' to tell them what was wrong with the boy; without a diagnosis, 'the ladies . . . and the servants in general were not reassured'.

Salim recovered, however, and Akbar was unfazed. Cures and visions, prophesies and miracles tumbled one after the other over the following months, with all the speed of the emperor chasing an enemy.

In the very month of Salim's illness, Akbar gave 'medical remedies, and . . . spiritual medicines' to a poisoned courtier; later that summer, the emperor used his 'Messiah-like breath' to perform an eye operation on his cheetah-keeper; and in October that year, he fed a wild deer from his own hand, while onlookers gazed in amazement.[29] This was nothing, however, to the miracle that awaited in November, when Akbar saved the whole of his empire from the baleful influence of a comet, the 'blessing of the holy personality' keeping its curse at bay.

In mid-December that year, Sadiq Khan was among the Mughal generals leading a punitive expedition against the raja of Orchha. It wasn't long ago that Sadiq Khan had been punished himself – he had lost one of Akbar's elephants to the Ganga's waters during the march to Patna. Furious – and rather unjustly so, given how many imperial animals drowned thanks to his own madcap navigation of the rivers to Bihar – Akbar had confiscated Sadiq Khan's estate and banished him to Sindh, with orders not to return without a replacement for the deceased beast. It was many months and the gift of 100 elephants later that Sadiq Khan was able to win his way back into favour.

Now, hacking through a jungle to confront Orchha's raja, it looked like Sadiq Khan might be in trouble again. Two hundred Rajputs in the Mughal army had already been killed, the battle was getting out of hand. Desperate, Sadiq Khan conjured an image of Akbar in his mind and made one last charge. 'Suddenly,' the victorious khan would later tell the court, the emperor's 'standards appeared, and [his] glorious figure', too. Of course, the Mughals won.

The next year, in January 1578, Akbar was camped in a village in Punjab, lecturing his gathered nobility on the virtues of vegetarianism. He had